

Making and Keeping Friends: The Importance of Being Similar

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ABSTRACT—*Similarity is central to friendship. The origins of homophily (love of the same) between friends are varied, but they all serve the same purpose: fostering compatibility and maintaining the rewards of affiliation. Interpersonal attraction is grounded on similarity. Similar individuals have much in common and find it easy to get along. Friends are selected on the basis of resemblances and friends influence one another to become more similar over time. Friends also resist changes that promote dissimilarity because differences increase the risk that the friendship will dissolve. Similarity is an essential feature of friendship at all stages of life, but it assumes special significance during adolescence when changes in autonomy coincide with changes in the social world to raise the profile of friends.*

KEYWORDS—*peers; influence; friendship*

Friendships are a special form of close relationships. Humans have evolved mechanisms to detect friends from foes. One such mechanism, found even among prelinguistic infants, is preference for similar others (1). Similarity helps separate kin from nonkin. With resemblances on par with distant cousins, friends qualify as near-kin, individuals whose similarities signal preference for the same phenotypically compatible environments (2). Yet friends differ from kin in one key respect: Friends are voluntary affiliates (3). Two people have to agree to establish a

friendship. They also have to agree to continue a friendship. Friends must resolve their differences in a mutually acceptable manner because either party can terminate a friendship at any time. The distinctive properties of friendship raise questions about how and why they begin and end. In this article, I argue that similarity is essential to friendship. The principles outlined presumably apply to all stages of life, but they are especially significant during the second decade as adults loosen control over social activities and adolescents exercise greater freedom in their choice of companions.

A CONCEPTUAL OVERVIEW OF THE ROLE OF SIMILARITY IN FRIENDSHIP

The similarity–attraction model provides a framework for many scientific approaches to friendship. The model holds that similarity reflects compatibility, which both motivates and organizes friendships (4). Consider the folk saying “birds of a feather flock together.” Similar individuals have much in common and find it easy to get along. Compatibility fosters cooperation, which makes interactions rewarding and helps smooth over interpersonal difficulties when they arise. It follows that adolescents should seek compatible others and be attracted to those who share their attributes and interests. Similarity provides common ground for initial social engagements. Compatibility helps ensure that early exchanges are rewarding. When two individuals hit it off, they are inclined to get together again, whereas those who differ in ways that provoke irritation are unlikely to maintain contact (5). As interconnections and interdependence grow, partners influence one another to become even more similar, through rewards and emulation, as well as through pressure and compromise. The press for greater similarity is practical: Dissimilar friends risk becoming former friends, supplanted by those who offer the promise of a more satisfying relationship free of the conflict that arises from incompatible views and behaviors.

Consider an alternative view. The distinctiveness model holds that differences—not similarities—are the foundation for

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compatibility. Another folk saying captures this perspective: “opposites attract.” The distinctiveness model argues that inquisitiveness initially motivates people to engage with dissimilar others. The interactions that ensue are stimulating and more rewarding than the predictable, somewhat boring exchanges that occur between similar others. Thus, novelty reinforces initial attraction to dissimilar others, increasing the likelihood of subsequent social engagements. Complementarity bolsters attraction. Befriending peers with diverging strengths can compensate for deficiencies (6). As friends learn to capitalize on one another’s strengths, they become more dissimilar, adopting unique identities and honing special skills based on the complementary allocation of roles and responsibilities. Distinctiveness should also make friendships more stable. Friends with different skills and aptitudes avoid competition and rivalry, thereby minimizing sources of conflict that can erode the foundation of the relationship. The case for complementarity rests almost exclusively on interpersonal styles of social interaction (7). During interchanges, successful adult romantic partners and friends prefer and elicit dissimilar expressions of power (i.e., dominance begets submissiveness and submissiveness begets dominance).

HOMOPHILY

Homophily means love of the same. It refers to similarities among affiliates (8). We have long known that children’s social networks include peers who share sociodemographic characteristics (9). Friends also share resemblances on a wide range of attributes and traits, including prosocial and antisocial behavior, shyness and internalizing symptoms, and peer sociometric status (10). But concurrent concordances, however compelling, do not prove that friendships are grounded in similarity because the origins of homophily can be traced to many sources.

Selection describes attraction to similar others (11). Similarity can be ascribed to selection when adolescents form new friendships with consonant partners with whom they were previously unaffiliated. *Repulsion* describes avoidance on the basis of dissimilarity (12). Similarity can be ascribed to repulsion when adolescents form antipathies for people who are different, eliminating dissimilar others from the pool of potential friends. *Influence* describes similarity arising from experiences with friends (13). Similarity can be ascribed to influence when adolescents change in ways that increase resemblances or avoid changes that decrease resemblances. *Deselection* describes the dissolution of friendships because of dissimilarity (14). Similarity can be ascribed to the departure of outliers in groups and the disintegration of friendships between dissonant partners, both of which increase homogeneity among those who retain connections. Next, I review each of these concepts.

Selection

Is the selection of friends grounded in attraction to similar others? The first answers to this question came from longitudinal

studies that identified similarities among adolescents who were not friends at the beginning of the school year but who were friends at the end (15). Initial resemblances were substantial; adolescents were more likely to choose similar classmates as friends than nonsimilar classmates. Subsequent studies (16) confirmed another key finding: Selection similarities are greater for observable attributes and behaviors than for internal preferences and attitudes. Thus, attraction has origins in salient cues that signal similarity.

Methodological concerns about this work soon came to light. Estimates of similarity can be inflated by stereotype accuracy, a bias arising when members of a category of individuals respond or behave in the same (stereotypical) manner (17). Absent statistical corrections, friends will appear more similar than they actually are because of chance agreement between those who share social contexts and developmental timetables; the problem is especially acute in studies where nominations of friends—usually in the form of questionnaires asking youth to identify friends—are restricted (as they often are) to participants of the same sex, same grade, or same school.

Corrections for chance agreement attenuate but do not eliminate evidence of selection similarity. To illustrate, new friendships (dyads in which neither student nominated the other as a friend or affiliate the previous year) that were stable for at least 1 year were identified in a community sample of adolescents whose nominations were not constrained by grade or school (18). Comparing future friends (within-dyad correlations the year before the friendship began) to nonfriends (within-dyad correlations between randomly paired participants who never nominated the other as a friend or an affiliate) confirms that similarity anticipates the formation of friendships, especially on salient observable variables (see Figure 1). Within-dyad correlations on behaviors were twice as large for adolescents who later became friends than for those who remained nonfriends, before and after corrections for chance agreement. Differences between future friends and nonfriends on attitudes did not rise to the level of statistical significance, consistent with assertions that initial attractions between prospective friends are motivated by reputational salience (19), which is derived primarily from overt behaviors. In the same vein, meta-analytic results indicate that perceived similarities are stronger predictors of interpersonal attraction between adults than are actual similarities (20), a finding that helps explain why similarity on self-reports of behaviors is more successful in predicting friendship formation than similarity on self-reports of attitudes.

Repulsion

Is the selection of friends constrained by an aversion for dissimilar others? A modified version of the repulsion hypothesis holds that selection similarity is framed and enhanced by the tendency to dislike those who are different, narrowing the pool of friend options to those who are more apt to share resemblances (21). In

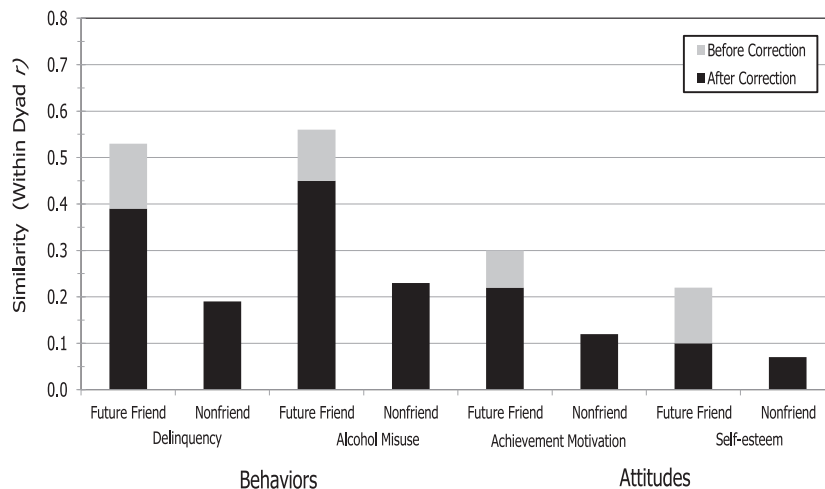


Figure 1. Selection of similar others: Adolescents who become friends (future friends) are more similar than adolescents who do not become friends (nonfriends).

Note. Data adapted from Hafen et al. (18). Correlations between randomly paired nonfriends were unchanged by corrections for chance agreement arising from cohort similarity.

this view, distinctiveness is more than irrelevant to the formation of friendships; it is antithetical to it.

It is difficult to disentangle evidence of dissimilarity repulsion from evidence of similarity–attraction because most studies treat dissimilarity and similarity as opposing poles that anchor a single continuum. Although it is technically true that the tendency for similar others to become friends also indicates a tendency for dissimilar others to avert friendship, the latter is not the preferred interpretation. Experimental studies that control for one while using the other to predict attraction suggest that both similarity and dissimilarity play a role in the formation of children's friendships (22). But studies of this sort are rare. Instead, support for dissimilarity repulsion rests primarily on evidence of antipathy.

We know something about the targets of enmity: Popular adolescents dislike unpopular peers (23), and children and the classmates they dislike are inversely correlated on prosociality, withdrawal, and aggression (24). We know less about reciprocated antipathies. Many such dyads involve a partner who bullies and a partner who is withdrawn or victimized (25). No studies have examined whether dyadic differences on a common trait predict mutual enmity.

Group antipathies are another story. The case for dissimilarity repulsion is bolstered by research on peer groups. Experiments suggest that rivalries thrive on dissimilarity. Individuals report that they have little in common with members of rival out-groups (26). Ethnographies describe schools beset by rivalries between groups with diverging values. One classic ethnographic study described enmity between *burnouts*, who were alienated from mainstream school culture, and *jocks*, who embraced the school culture (27). A recent empirical study quantified this dynamic: Members of peer groups described reciprocated intergroup

enmities. Consistent with the model of dissimilarity repulsion, characteristics of the group to which adolescents belonged predicted the degree of antipathy they held for others (28). For example, students in peer groups whose members reported few problem behaviors disliked students in peer groups whose members reported many problem behaviors, and vice versa (see Figure 2). Similar findings emerged for school grades and school burnout.

In summary, the literature is unequivocal on the matter of distinctiveness: Friendships are not grounded on differences. Instead, concordance is the foundation of friendship. Resemblances between friends arise because similarity is an attractor and dissimilarity is a repellent. There is more to learn. The field needs longitudinal studies that depict the interplay of similarity and repulsion, and that quantify their relative importance.

Influence

Does the influence of friends promote similarity? Peer pressure has many motives, but most produce the same effect: Maintaining or enhancing resemblances that foster compatibility and diminishing differences that might otherwise be roadblocks to a successful friendship. Not all influence is a product of pressure. Sometimes peer influence takes the form of emulation. Imitators seek to become more similar to those who serve as models, hoping to attain the same kind of benefits seen to flow to the model, or minimally, hoping to receive benefits that spill over from basking in the model's reflected glory (29). Peer influence is sometimes a by-product of engagement and companionship, a response to the rewards of social interactions. Sometimes peer influence arises in response to disequilibrium. Cooperation is a source of consonance, eliminating cognitive dissonance; coordination improves compatibility, synchronizing behaviors (30).

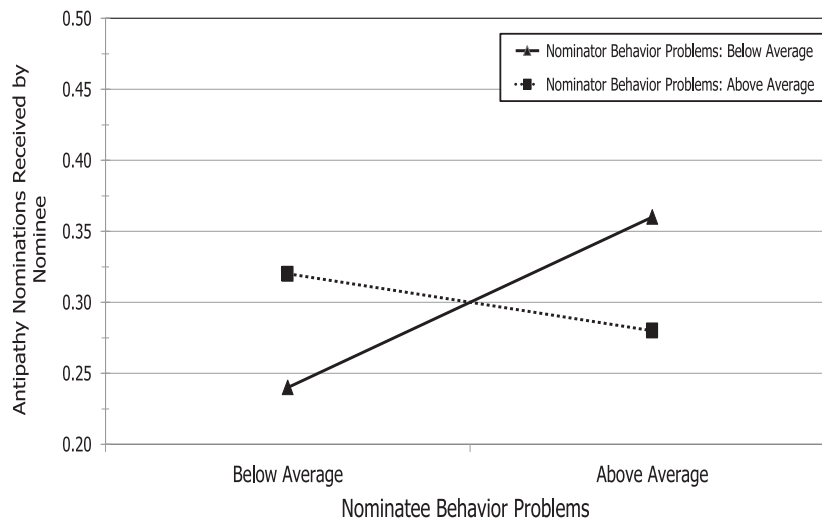


Figure 2. Repulsion of dissimilar others: Antipathies grow as group differences on behavior problems increase.
Note. Reprinted from Laursen et al. (28). Reprinted with permission from Elsevier.

Compliance is also a marker of influence. Acquiescence, whether coerced or embraced, increases resemblances as activities and attitudes become increasingly entwined (31). Thus, adolescents establish friendships based on similarity and then exercise influence to strengthen ties that increase similarities. The potential unexpected side effects of increased similarity are worth noting: What is good for the relationship in terms of increased solidarity may be bad for the individual if heightened consonance was attained through corumination (extensively discussing problems and sharing negative affect) or risk taking.

All of which raises the question: Within a friendship, who influences whom? If similarity is to increase, one or both friends must change to resemble the other. Conformity implies mutual influence that results in changes to both friends. The behaviors and attitudes of each friend may converge in the middle (one increasing and the other decreasing), or they may start near the same point and move together in the same direction (32). Evidence of conformity is stronger at the level of the peer group, where it reflects pressure to adopt norms and conventions, than it is at the level of the friend dyad, where it suggests compromise and collaboration.

Influence within a friendship is often unilateral and unidirectional. In these instances, only one member of the dyad changes to resemble the other, with the direction of change dictated by the more influential friend. One partner may be particularly susceptible to influence while another is particularly influential; who occupies which role reflects differences in needs, traits, and abilities. For example, consider how the influence of friends varies as a function of their relative acceptance by peers (33). The partner with fewer options for friends (i.e., the one who is less accepted by peers) changed to resemble more closely the partner with more options for friends, but

not the reverse. Thus, delinquency increased among less-accepted partners whose friends were initially more delinquent, whereas delinquency declined modestly among less-accepted partners whose friends were initially less delinquent. Influence and susceptibility to influence are also a product of self-understanding. Task performance usually reflects priorities—adolescents prefer friends who are unlikely to upstage them on matters they deem important (34)—but when performance lags, friends are expected to yield on matters central to an individual's identity.

Eventually, the influence of friends shifts from the goal of promoting similarity to the goal of preserving similarity. Once similar, friends should resist changes that might decrease compatibility. Other relationships can interfere with this goal. During adolescence, the greatest challenge comes from romantic partners, who increasingly rival and eventually surpass friends in terms of closeness (35). In one study, almost half of all middle-school respondents reported feeling excluded when a friend began dating (36). No doubt friends are aware that changes in similarity reflect contracting influence and shifting relationship priorities. Figure 3 illustrates how between-friend correlations on alcohol misuse declined after adolescents acquired a new romantic partner; in contrast, correlations were unchanged among friends who did not acquire romantic partners (37). Romantic partners can be blamed for diminished resemblances to friends. At the same time that similarity to friends decreased, similarity to new romantic partners increased to levels that rivaled those of friends without romantic partners. Participating in romantic relationships may mark a developmental transition, reducing the importance of sustained similarity to the stability of friendships. Adult friends recognize that their influence pales beside that of romantic partners. Declining rates in the turnover of friendships may signal a greater tolerance of individual

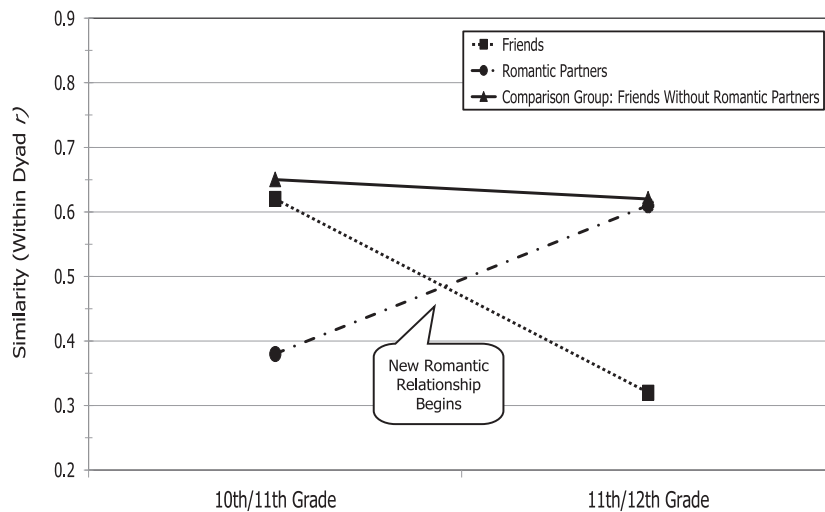


Figure 3. Peer influence promotes similarity: Friends become less similar and romantic partners become more similar on alcohol misuse following the establishment of a new romantic relationship.

Note. Data adapted from DeLay et al. (37).

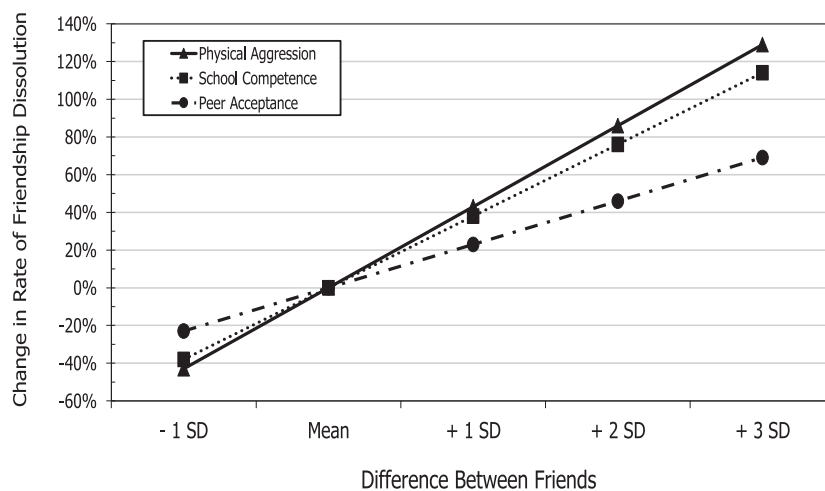


Figure 4. Deselection of dissimilar others: Annual rate of friendship dissolution grows as differences between friends increase.

Note. Data adapted from Hartl et al. (44).

changes that reduce dyadic similarity (as long as those changes do not interfere with compatibility).

Deselection

Does dissimilarity threaten the stability of friendships? If dyadic similarity is a marker of compatibility, which fosters the formation of friendships, then dyadic dissimilarity should signal incompatibility, which should forecast deselection (the dissolution of a friendship because of dissimilarity). Incompatibility is corrosive—it breeds negative thoughts and deeds. Differences invite disagreement over preferences, goals, and behaviors (38). Successful friends can overcome differences through negotiation (another form of influence), prompting changes in one or both

partners that improve compatibility. Failure to bridge the dissimilarity gap is a bad omen for a friendship. In terms of social exchange, differences change perceptions of equity as friends believe that they do not share the benefits of affiliation equally. Such perceptions are not unfounded; when friends are dissimilar, one partner is apt to bear more costs (e.g., the less aggressive friend) or accrue more rewards (e.g., the less humorous friend) than the other. Negative interactions and perceptions of inequality take a toll on satisfaction with the relationship. Ultimately, dissatisfied friends are likely to become former friends, replaced by more compatible partners.

Dissimilarity predicts deselection. The degree to which friends differ on aggression and victimization foretells instability

in friendships (39), as do differences in school achievement (40). But conclusions about the causes of instability are complicated by the fact that dyadic dissimilarity is confounded with elevated levels of individual attributes: The largest differences between friends tend to involve adolescents with the most pronounced characteristics. Therefore, the argument that undesirable characteristics are a source of dissatisfaction with friends may also be valid. Adolescents with poor social skills miss interpersonal cues and fail to provide support when needed and expected (41). Adolescents with emotional and behavioral problems are prone to negative affect and unpredictable behavior (42). Unskilled and poorly regulated adolescents may break off friendships; however it is more likely that their partners decide to do so first (43). Put simply, many adolescents have attributes that make it difficult to be tolerated as friends.

One recent investigation that considered dyadic differences and off-putting individual attributes as causes of instability in friendships concluded that adolescent friendships dissolve primarily because of dissimilarity (44). Specifically, friends who differed on peer acceptance, physical aggression, and school competence had relationships that ended sooner than friends who were similar on these attributes. The risk of deselection is not trivial: Annual rates of dissolution grew by 20–40% for every 1 *SD* difference between friends (see Figure 4). Clearly, dissimilarity is an obstacle to compatibility between friends and a deterrent to the continuity of a friendship.

CONCLUSIONS

Friendships form on the basis of similarity. Friends then influence one another in ways that increase similarity. Compatibility flows from similarity. Dissimilarity increases the potential for discontent, which can be grounds for ending a friendship. Similarity undoubtedly plays a significant role in friendships at all stages of life, but adolescents are especially prone to emphasize consonance. Children and adults face practical constraints in selecting and maintaining friends, constraints that may undermine similarity. Children are limited in their selection of friends to those who are nearby, but not necessarily as similar as they might wish. In much the same way, adults' options for friends are subordinate to romantic, family, and employment relationships and to the obligations that extend from them. Adolescents, who have relatively unconstrained friendship options, may place a special premium on similarity because in the absence of a fully formed identity, solidarity with friends can aid in navigating an uncertain, shifting social landscape. Yet, even adolescents do not have unlimited friendship options. Forced to choose between friendlessness and friendship with undesirable others, most opt for the latter (45), even if it means tolerating tension, sacrificing similarity, and compromising compatibility.

On what features are friends most similar? We lack good answers to the question. Characteristics that matter to some friends do not matter to others, a fact that attenuates the

magnitude of our measured effects and limits our conclusions concerning the traits, behaviors, and attitudes that are most important to the success of a friendship. We cannot be certain which properties are the most salient to which friends. Nor do we know if the properties that motivate adolescents to select friends retain their importance over the course of the relationship. It seems reasonable to assume that friendships end for different reasons than they begin, but we do not know this to be a fact. We can say that a bad habit is not necessarily a turnoff, as long as both friends share the same habit and both friends consider it important.

What should we tell adolescents who have trouble making and keeping friends? Compatibility is the key to a successful friendship. Adolescents who have difficulties making friends should be advised about the importance of similarity in creating friendships, and should be encouraged to seek companions with whom they share constructive attributes. Adolescents who have difficulties keeping friends should be counseled on the distinction between similarity and synchrony. Positive friendships are hard to replace, and some adolescents may need to relax their expectations of conformity as long as they do not interfere with shared enjoyment.

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